

Laser Focus

Condensed notes from Ali Abdaal's 7-day email course on focus.

The 5 Fundamental Truths About Focus

1. Focus is a Trainable Skill

- **Neuroplasticity is real:** Your brain physically changes through practice
- Neural pathways strengthen with persistence and deliberate practice
- Like leveling up in a video game - you can get better at focusing

2. All Distractions Come From Within

- **There are no external distractions** - only internal responses
- Distraction is a passive coping strategy your brain uses to avoid:
 - Loneliness
 - Stress
 - Anxiety
 - Discomfort
- Address the root cause, not the symptoms

3. Laziness is Not the Real Problem

- Laziness is a symptom, not the cause of poor focus
- **Real solutions:**
 - Take regular breaks
 - Set realistic expectations
 - Avoid self-fulfilling prophecies
- Stop using "laziness" as an excuse - dig deeper

4. Motivation Follows Action (Not the Other Way Around)

- **Waiting for motivation is the wrong approach**
- You have agency to build motivation through action
- Start first, motivation will follow

5. Your Environment Matters Less Than You Think

- Needing the "perfect" environment is an excuse

- **Optimal focus comes from within**
 - Use small time windows to make progress anywhere
 - Don't wait for ideal conditions
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The 90-20 Work Cycle System

Ultradian Rhythms (90-Minute Cycles)

- **90 minutes work → 20 minutes rest**
 - Natural human attention cycles exist - work with them, not against them
 - First cycle begins when you're most awake (typically after waking)
 - **Goal: Two high-quality 90-minute cycles per day**
 - At the first sign of depletion, STOP and take a break
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Managing Attention Residue

The Hidden Focus Killer

- **Task switching destroys deep work**
- Increases cognitive load
- Slows you down
- Reduces work quality
- **Protect deep focus blocks like they're money**

Time Blocking Strategy

Create dedicated blocks for different work types:

- **Deep Focus Blocks:** 90-minute protected periods for complex work
- **BAU Blocks:** 3× 30-minute sessions for routine tasks
 - Start of work day
 - Early afternoon
 - Late afternoon wrap-up
- **Meeting Blocks:** Cluster meetings together

- **Communication Blocks:** Handle emails, messages, etc.

The Ready-to-Resume (R2R) Plan

Before switching tasks, take 1 minute to write:

- What you were doing
 - What you intended to do next
 - Where to continue when you return
 - **Result:** Massively reduces attention residue
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Minimizing Digital Distractions

Phone & Device Settings

- **Focus Mode:** DND + schedule
 - **Greyscale Mode:** Reduces phone appeal
 - **Forest App:** With anti-switch feature
 - **One-Sec App:** Blocks impulse app usage
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Environment Optimization

Physical Space

- **Clean, simple environment enhances focus**
- Messy environment scatters attention
- **Dedicate a specific location for deep work**
 - Primes your brain for focus
 - Can be as simple as the edge of the kitchen table

Digital Space

- **Declutter your digital environment too**
- Both physical and digital clutter reflect mental clutter
- Clean workspace = clear mind

Performance Enhancement Tools

Binaural Beats

- Can enhance focus when used:
 - During a focus session, OR
 - Before starting quiet deep work
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Key Takeaway

Focus is not about willpower or perfect conditions. It's about understanding your brain's natural rhythms, eliminating internal distractions at their source, taking action before motivation arrives, and protecting your attention like the valuable resource it is.

Action List: Implement These Today

Immediate Actions (Do Right Now)

1. **Set up Focus Mode** on your phone with a schedule for your deep work blocks
2. **Enable Greyscale Mode** on your phone to reduce digital appeal
3. **Block your calendar** for two 90-minute deep focus sessions tomorrow
4. **Install focus tools:**
 - Forest app (with anti-switch enabled)
 - One-Sec app (to block impulse usage)
5. **Create 3× 30-minute BAU blocks** in your calendar for tomorrow:
 - Morning: Start of day routine tasks
 - Midday: Early afternoon administration
 - Evening: End of day wrap-up

Before Your Next Deep Work Session

6. **Write an R2R Plan template** and keep it accessible (notepad, app, etc.)
7. **Clear your physical workspace** - remove clutter and distractions
8. **Clear your digital workspace:**
 - Close unnecessary browser tabs
 - Quit unused applications
 - Organize desktop files
9. **Identify your first 90-minute cycle time** - when are you most awake?
10. **Prepare binaural beats** playlist or app for focus sessions

During Your Work Sessions

11. **Write an R2R Plan before any task switch** (takes 1 minute, saves hours)
12. **Stop at the first sign of depletion** - don't push past 90 minutes
13. **Take full 20-minute breaks** between cycles - no screens, walk around
14. **Avoid task switching** during deep work blocks - protect them fiercely

Daily Practices

15. **Track your two best 90-minute cycles** each day
16. **Practice focusing deliberately** - remember: neuroplasticity improves with practice
17. **When you feel distracted, ask:** "What discomfort am I avoiding right now?"
18. **Take action before waiting for motivation** - motivation follows action
19. **Use small time windows** for progress - don't wait for perfect conditions

Weekly Review

20. **Assess what's working** - which focus techniques helped most?
21. **Identify internal distractions** - what emotions trigger your task switching?
22. **Adjust your schedule** - are your 90-minute blocks at optimal times?
23. **Celebrate progress** - acknowledge improvements in focus ability